College of Social and Behavioral Sciences
Master of Arts in Clinical Mental Health Counseling
COUN 5553 Professional Orientation and Law and Ethics
Spring 2026

Instructor:
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Office Hours:
By appointment only. Please contact me to schedule an appointment.

Theme Scripture: A new command I give you: Love one another. As I have loved you, so you must love one another. John 13:34 (NIV)

Class Schedule: 6pm-10pm on Thursday on the following dates
Thursday, January 15
Thursday, January 22
Thursday, January 29
Thursday, February 12
Thursday, February 19
Thursday, March 12
Thursday, March 26
Thursday, April 16

Required Text:
Remley, T. P., & Herlihy, B. P. (2024). Ethical, Legal, and Professional Issues in Counseling (7th edition). Pearson. ISBN-13: 9780138168094

Recommended Text:
Newkrug, E. (2022) A Brief Orientation to Counseling Professional Identity, History, and Standards (Third Edition). Cognella.

Course description:
In this course, students will understand the history, philosophy, and practice of counseling. Specific attention is given to legal and ethical standards for licensed counselors.

Course Objectives
1. Explain the legal and ethical standards in the practice of counseling.
2. Articulate professional identity and responsibilities of a counselor.

3. Select the appropriate legal and ethical actions to take in counseling setting.

CACREP Standards:

2F.1.a history and philosophy of the counseling profession and its specialty areas
2F.1.d the role and process of the professional counselor advocating on behalf of the profession
2F.1.f. professional counseling organizations, including membership benefits, activities, services to members, and current issues.
2F.1.g. professional counseling credentialing, including certification, licensure, and accreditation practices and standards, and the effects of public policy on these issues
2F.1.i. ethical standards of professional counseling organizations and credentialing bodies, and applications of ethical and legal considerations in professional counseling.
2F.1.j. technology's impact on the counseling profession.
2F.1.l. self-care strategies appropriate to the counselor role
2F.5.e. the impact of technology on the counseling process
3G.15 procedures for identifying and reporting signs of abuse and neglect
5C.1.a. history and development of clinical mental health counseling
5C.2.i. legislation and government policy relevant to clinical mental health counseling
5C.2.l. legal and ethical considerations specific to clinical mental health counseling
5C.3.c strategies for interfacing with the legal system regarding court-referred clients

5C.3.d strategies for interfacing with integrated behavioral health care professionals

Outcomes							
Objectives	*Quiz 1*	*Quiz 2*	*Code of Ethics Paper*	*Online trainings*	*Written Exam*	*Personalized inform consent document*	*Discussions and class activities*
2F. 1a	X		X				X
2F 1d	X						X
2F 1f	X				X		X
2F lg	X				X		X
2F 1i	X	X	X		X	X	X
2F 1j		X	X	X	X	X	X
2F 1l	X	X	X		X		X
2F 5e			X	X	X	X	X
3.G.15		X		X	X		X
5C 1a	X		X				X
5C 2i	X	X	X	X	X		X
5c 2l	X	X	X	X	X	X	X
5C.3.c	X	X			X		X
5C.3.d	X	X			X	X	X

Key Performance Indicators (KPI)									
Assignments	**KPI 1**	**KPI 2**	**KPI 3**	**KPI 4**	**KPI 5**	**KPI 6**	**KPI 7**	**KPI 8**	**KPI 9**
Written Exam	X								

Academic Honesty:
Northwest University expects honesty from students in all areas, including their academic lives. Academic dishonesty is a serious violation of university standards and may result in receiving an "F" on the assignment, receiving an "F" for the course, or being dismissed from the University. Instances of academic dishonesty are coordinated through the respective graduate program office and typically reported to the Provost's Office.
Academic dishonesty includes cheating on assignments or examinations, submitting the same (or essentially the same) paper in more than one course without prior consent of the current assigning professor(s), sabotaging another student's work, and plagiarizing. Plagiarism is "using someone else's ideas or phrasing and representing those ideas or phrasing as our own, either on purpose or through carelessness" (MLA). Any student disciplined by a faculty member for alleged academic dishonesty has the right to appeal the disciplinary action. The student should initiate his/her appeal according to procedures outlined in the Northwest University Student Academic Appeals Policy, which is available in the provost's office.

Attendance Policy:
Class attendance is extremely important for student learning and achievement of specified course outcomes, and, in turn, the program aims. Hence, attendance at all class sessions is expected. At minimum, students absent for a class session will need to make up any missed assignments or exercises and complete the expected readings. A grade penalty will be applied if more than one class session is missed. Additional policies and consequences are at the discretion of the individual professor of the course. More than one missed class session will result in failure of the course and require a retake to continue in the program. In this circumstance, the student is encouraged to withdraw from the course and retake the class when it is offered again. In the event of unusual circumstances (e.g., extended illness, emergency), a student may appeal the automatic course failure. A proposal outlining a plan for satisfactory course completion will be required, composed by the professor, and agreed to by the student. In addition, the plan will require approval by the program director and Dean.

Disability Accommodations and Procedures:
For students with learning differences and/or physical disabilities, as defined by the ADA and Section 504 of the Rehabilitation Act, Northwest University takes an individual and holistic approach to providing accommodations. Accommodations are developed and approved on an individual basis by the Student Development Office, not the CMHC program or individual faculty members. Students needing accommodations for a diagnosed disability should follow the procedures provided on the Student Development Office's website for disability accommodations.

Communication Policy:
Timely communication between the professor and students is important to the program's overall functioning. Therefore, both students and faculty should respond to email or phone messages within two business days. If the professor is out-of-office, she will have an automatic reply message (on email) providing the return date and an in-office contact for urgent requests.

Grading Policy:
Grading is conducted on the Discovery Grade Book page of the course. Students are expected to monitor their progress accordingly. Assignments and tests will generally be graded within two weeks. Final papers and projects may take up to three weeks. The professor will let you know if there are exceptional circumstances preventing a timely return of grades. If you have concerns about grading timing, please check with the professor, program coordinator, or program Chair.

Late Work Policy:
It is the student's responsibility to meet all deadlines for class assignments. Late work will be accepted one week after the due date with a 10% grade penalty. It is your responsibility to communicate with the professor promptly about late work and absences.

Mechanics of the Course:

A) Class Sessions:
Class sessions will be used for a variety of purposes including:

1. Lecture
2. In Class Discussions
3. Small Group Exercises
4. Quizzes
5. Written Exam

B) Quizzes and Tests:
1. There will be two multiple-choice and/or True-False examinations in class.

- Quiz 1: Fifth class session (during regular class time) Covered topics will be lectures and chapters 1-8.

- Quiz 2: Final class session (during regular class time) Covered topics will be lectures and chapters 9-16. Quizzes must be completed by the last day of the semester.

2. Law and Ethics Written Case Study Exam (in class, March 26)

Each student will be given a case vignette related to legal and ethical counseling issues. The student will have two hours to complete a written response to the case study where they must: 1. Identify any legal issues, 2. Identify any ethical issues. 3. Identify law or ACA ethical codes that address the issues in the case and how they are relevant, 4. In light of the legal and ethical issues, outline 3-5 clinical steps (short term and long term) they plan to take the client through during their sessions, and 5. Discuss what outside agencies/resources should be included or offered to the client to address legal and ethical issues in the short-term and long-term. The law and ethics

qualifying exam will be graded on the legal and ethical issues identified, and the short and long-term steps taken to help the client in the case. Students will not be allowed to consult resources or notes when taking this exam. **This exam is used as a key performance indicator for student proficiency in Professional Counseling Orientation and Ethical Practice. This exam must be passed with an 80% or above to pass the class.**

C) Response, Research, or Other Written Assignments:

1. **There will be three professional development tasks (see Discovery for instructions):**
   - Professional communication with clinical placement sites (due Jan 24)
   - Online Telehealth Training (due Feb 14)
   - Online Mandatory Reporting Training (due Feb 14)

2. **Personalized inform consent document (due Jan 31)**: develop a personalized informed consent document (see examples in your text, Appendix B) that will be applicable for you to use in clinical training at your site. Cite any templates or sources used to create your personalized document. Bring rough drafts of your document to class #3. In small groups, you will discuss possible additions or deletions to the documents. Final drafts will be due the Saturday after class #3. At a minimum, please include the following (50 points, 5 points for addressing each area below):
   - Purposes, goals, techniques, procedures, limitations, and potential risks and benefits of services
   - Your qualifications (counseling student and under supervision with a licensed professional)
   - Information about termination and referrals
   - Emergency protocols and crisis resources
   - The role of technology
   - The implications of diagnosis and intended use of testing and reports
   - Fees and billing information
   - Confidentiality and its limitations
   - The right to obtain records and actively participate in ongoing counseling plans
   - The right to refuse recommended services or modality change and be advised of the consequences of refusal**.**

3. **Code of Ethics Principle Paper (due March 14)**– Choose one of the six ethical principles outlined in the American Counseling Association's (ACA) code of ethics (autonomy, nonmaleficence, beneficence, justice, fidelity or veracity) and research the principle in depth in three ways. The code of ethics should follow APA style formatting and be 6-8 pages in length.

   1. Explore the identified ethical principle within the counseling field.
      - Why is the ethical principle foundational for counseling? Consider the history of this principle within the field (look for evidence in counseling theory, counselor identity and/or development of counseling). Offer two references.

- Identify other mental health ethical codes that consider this principle. Offer two references.
- What does current counseling literature say about this principle? Consider work with diverse populations. Offer at least one reference.

2. Explain how ACA standards reflect the principle you researched.
   - Identify three standards from the ACA code of ethics and explain how the principle you have researched is reflected in each of the standards. Put the standards in your own words and consider how you will put them to practice in your work.
     - Consider at least 2 subpoints in each identified standard
   - Each student must include a standard from section H: Distance Counseling, Technology and Social Media.
3. Explore the ethical principle from a Christian perspective.
   - Which Christian virtue/virtues relate to the ethical principle?
   - What does Christian doctrine teach on this principle? Include at two biblical references.
   - Include one example of the virtue within church history or tradition.
   - Identify a personal practice that may aid in developing this principle or virtue for a clinician.

D) Participation:

A portion of the student's final grade will be based on their participation in class including group discussions, class exercises, individual and group presentations of discussion material, and attendance. Full points will be rewarded to those students who attend all the class sessions and actively participate in class activities.

E) Grading:

Exams and papers will be graded within 2 weeks. The students' course grade will be based upon her/his mastery of course terms, concept, and objections as demonstrated by classroom attendance, participation in classroom activities and dialogue, discussions and papers. Please be on time with all assignments. Late work will be accepted one week after the due date with a 10% grade penalty.

Grading is conducted on the Discovery Grade Book page of the course. Students are expected to monitor their progress.

Grading Scale:

A	100-94%	C	76-74%
A-	93-90%	C-	73-70%
B+	89-87%	D+	69-67%
B	86-84%	D	66-64%
B-	83-80%	D-	63-60%
C+	79-77%	F	59% and below

F) Course Values

Class	***Item***	***Point Value***
2	Professional Communication	10
3	Informed Consent Document	50
4	Telehealth Training	5
4	Mandatory Reporting Training	5
5, 8	Two Quizzes (80 each)	160
6	Code of Ethics Paper	140
7	Written Exam (KPI)	50
All classes	Class Participation (10 points/class)	80
		Total: 500

G) Lecture, Reading, and Assignment Outline:
This guide serves as an outline for the course. Please refer to Discovery for detailed instructions for assignments, reading, and specific due dates for this course. Dates for specific lecture topics may change and material may need to be added or deleted. If any changes are made, they will be announced in class.

Class Date	**Reading/Multimedia**	**Topics**	**Due:**	**In-Class Activities**	**CACREP Standards Met**
Thursday, January 15 *Class 1*	Remley, T. P. & Herlihy, B. Chapters 1-2 • ACA Ethical Standards- https://www.counseling.org/resources/aca-code-of-ethics.pdf (Appendix A) • WA state Laws for counselors- https://apps.leg.wa.gov/WAC/default.aspx?cite=246-810	Orientation to professional law and ethics in counseling -principal ethics -virtue ethics -personal values -professional values Professional Identity of Counselors: -History of counseling -Counseling organizations -Licensure and current issues	**In class discussion**	Lecture Virtue ethics vs. principal ethics Character strengths test Discussion: -What role can counseling students play in the standardization and professionalization of counseling?	2.F.1.a 2.F.1.d, 2F.1.f, 2f.1.g, 2F.1.i, 5.C.1.a, 5C.2.1

				-CCS-R, 2k	
Thursday, January 22 *Class 2*	Remley, T. P. & Herlihy, B. Chapters 3-4	Multiculturalism social justice, advocacy Client rights and counselor responsibilities -fiduciary relationships -informed consent -court mandated clients	**In class discussion** **Professional communication due in Discovery Saturday by 11:59**	-Lecture -Case study group work -Informed consent group work Discussion: -CCS-R, 2f, g	2.F.1.d, 5C.2.1, 5C.3.c
Thursday, January 29 *Class 3*	Remley, T. P. & Herlihy, B. Chapters 5-6 https://app.leg.wa.gov/rcw/default.aspx?cite=18.225&full=true#18.225.105 https://www.dcyf.wa.gov/safety/report-abuse	Confidentiality and Record Keeping -privileged communication, confidentiality, privacy -records and subpoenas	**Personalized informed consent document due Saturday by 11:59**	-Lecture -Case study groups -Records and subpoenas activity Discussion: court mandated clients. -CCS-R,2d	2F.l.i, 3G.15 5C.2.i, 5C.2.1, 5C.3.c
Thursday, February 12 *Class 4*	Remley, T. P. & Herlihy, B. Chapters 7-8	Competence and Malpractice	**Complete free telehealth training (30**	-Lecture	2F.1.g, 2F1.i, 2F1,

	Complete the following online trainings: https://nrtrc.catalog.instructure.com/courses/washington-state-healthcare-professional-telemedicine-training https://risewiththealliance.org/programs/development-and-support-for-caregivers/mandatory-reporter/	-training, licensure, credentialing -Burnout and self-care -testing and dx -relevant legal cases -Tarasoff case -Volk v. DeMeerleer case	**min), and mandatory reporting training Saturday by 11:59**	-records and subpoenas case study -risk of harm case study Discussion: -CCS-R, 2e, h	l, 3G.15, 5C.2.1
Thursday February 19 *Class 5*	Remley, T. P. & Herlihy, B. Chapters 9-10	Boundary Issues and Technology in Counseling	**Quiz #1 in class, (chapters 1-8)**	-Lecture -group activity, technology -Quiz #1 Discussion: -CCS-R, c	2F.1.f, 2F.1.g 2F.1.j, 5C.2.i. 2F.5.e, 5C.2.1 5C.3.c
Thursday, March 12 *Class 6*	Remley, T. P. & Herlihy, B. Chapters 11-12 protecting the abused and neglected child	Children and vulnerable adults, families and groups	**Code of Ethics Principle Paper due by Saturday 11:59**	-Lecture -case study group work -Group activity: Confidentiality and family secrets Discussion: CCS-R, 2j	2F.l.i, 5C.2.i, 5C.2.1, 5C.3.c
Thursday March 26 *Class 7*	Remley, T. P. & Herlihy, B. Chapters 13-14 Henri Nouwen (1989)'s chapter from his book *Reflections on Christian Leadership* (link in Discovery)	Professional Relationships and issues in Counselor education	**Written exam in class**	-Lecture -Discussion in class -Written exam Discussion: CCS-R, b	2F.1.f. 5C.2.i, 5C.2.1, 5C.3.c 5C.3.d,

Thursday April 16 *Class 8*	Remley, T. P. & Herlihy, B.	Supervision and Consultation	**Quiz 2 Chapter 9-16 in class**	-Lecture Discussion: -CCS-R, 2h, i -Final quiz	2F.1.g, 5C.3.c 5C.3.d, 5C.2.1

Appendix A
Code of Ethics Paper Rubric

Evaluation	**Possible Points**
APA style adherence (proper citations, headings,	0-10
Writing quality, critical thinking, organization	0-10
Cover page, abstract, reference page	0-10
The ethical principle as it relates to counseling is thoroughly considered with each point substantively explained (5 references)	0-40
Three standards and two subpoints from the ACA code of ethics are identified and section H is considered	0-30
Christian virtue is clearly explained with each point thoroughly addressed (3 references)	0-40

Total: /140

Appendix B
Written Case Study Exam Rubric (50 points)

Criteria	Excels In all Criteria	Meets most Criteria	Meets Some Criteria	Criteria Not Met
	23-25 points	20-22 points	17-19 points	16 or fewer points
Accurate Identification of Ethical and Legal Issues **25 points possible**	Includes accurate identification of all ethical and legal issues as described by the ACA code of ethics and Washington State law (or state in which student resides), clear and specific description of how issues are in violation of ethical code and state laws.	Includes accurate identification of all ethical and legal issues as described by the ACA code of ethics and Washington State law (or state in which student resides), includes description of how issues are in violation of ethical code and state laws but may lack clarity/specificity.	Includes identification of major ethical and legal issues as described by the ACA code of ethics and Washington State law (or state in which student resides), includes description of how issues are in violation of ethical codes and state laws but is limited or unclear	Inaccurate and/or incomplete identification of ethical and legal issues as described by the ACA code of ethics and Washington State law (or state in which student resides), description of how issues are in violation of ethical codes and state laws is inaccurate and/or incomplete
Identification of appropriate action **25 points possible**	Includes accurate and thorough description of steps to rectify, avoid, or address ethical and legal issues identified in vignette.	Includes a relevant description of steps to rectify, avoid, or address ethical and legal issues identified in vignette.	Includes a limited description of steps to rectify, avoid, or address ethical and legal issues identified in vignette.	Description of appropriate action is missing, incomplete, inaccurate